

Teaching Statement

As an instructor, my primary goal is to cultivate lasting curiosity about economics by helping students develop the habit of thinking like economists. I want students to recognize that economics is not simply a collection of models and equations, but a powerful framework for understanding how individuals, firms, and governments make decisions under incentives and constraints. Whether students pursue careers in economics, public policy, business, or other fields, I hope they leave my classroom able to interpret current events, evaluate empirical evidence, recognize policy tradeoffs, and make informed decisions. In a professional public policy environment, this also means learning to apply economic reasoning to complex problems and communicate conclusions to audiences with different disciplinary and professional backgrounds. When students begin asking economic questions beyond the classroom, I know they have begun to use economics as a way of understanding real-world problems.

My teaching experience at the University of Wisconsin–Madison includes three appointments across introductory microeconomics and upper-level development economics. I currently lead four discussion sections serving approximately 100 students in Principles of Microeconomics (Econ 101). I previously served twice as a Teaching Assistant for The Growth and Development of Nations in the Global Economy (AAE 374): in Spring 2023 with Professor Jeremy Foltz and in Spring 2024 with Professor Vladimir Gimpelson. Across these appointments, I have led discussion sections, delivered course lectures, prepared instructional materials, held office hours, answered questions in person and by email, and helped students connect economic theory with empirical evidence and policy applications. Teaching courses ranging from introductory microeconomics to international trade, growth, migration, inequality, and institutions has prepared me to work with students at different levels and with varied academic backgrounds.

To make complicated theories approachable, I begin with a concrete question or real-world policy example before introducing the formal model. In The Growth and Development of Nations in the Global Economy (AAE 375), for example, I used China's Made in China 2025 initiative to illustrate how the production function and the Heckscher–Ohlin model can help explain a country's efforts to move toward more technology- and skill-intensive production. After working through the example together, I asked students to select countries that interested them and apply the theories from class to their development challenges. These exercises helped students understand both the countries they cared about and how economic models can be used to analyze real policy questions.

Because students learn in different ways, I use several complementary teaching methods. I combine prepared section notes with explanations at the board, graphs and other visual representations, small-group discussions and one-minute reflections. Group discussions allow students to compare approaches, articulate their reasoning, and learn from one another. One-minute reflections encourage students to identify the main insight from a lesson or a point they still find confusing. Together, these methods give students multiple ways to engage with the material while providing me with immediate information about their understanding.

For mathematically difficult material, I develop models and solve problems step by step at the board rather than presenting only completed derivations. Beginning with the economic question and building the model alongside students allows me to explain why each assumption, equation, and analytical step is needed. Working at the board also sets a manageable pace and lets me observe students' reactions, pause when confusion arises, and revisit difficult points. I prepare detailed

notes in advance so that I can anticipate common difficulties and emphasize the conceptual links among the mathematics, economic intuition, and policy application.

I also value communication with students beyond formal class time. Conversations before and after class and during office hours help me understand how students are responding to the material and identify concepts that require a different explanation. For example, after a student told me that examples and stories made abstract theories easier to understand, I incorporated more visual and real-world examples into subsequent discussions. Student evaluations similarly highlighted my use of examples, willingness to explain concepts in multiple ways, and availability during office hours. These interactions provide students with a low-pressure setting in which to express confusion and give me the feedback needed to make my teaching more accessible and effective.

This commitment is reflected in my student evaluations. One student wrote that I “worked hard to make sure that all students understood the course content,” while another emphasized that my handouts were well organized and made the purpose of each discussion clear. I also genuinely enjoy teaching because it is a form of continued learning. Preparing lessons allows me to revisit and deepen my understanding of economic concepts, while students’ questions often lead me to reconsider familiar ideas from new perspectives. Their presentations and discussions introduce me to countries, policy problems, and experiences that I might not otherwise encounter. I therefore view teaching as a reciprocal process in which my students and I learn from one another.

My research expands what I can bring into the classroom. As a development economist, I study how households, firms, and communities respond to climate shocks, labor-market constraints, and structural change. Drawing on this work, I show students how economists transform real-world policy problems into researchable questions, use theory to identify mechanisms, and evaluate those mechanisms with empirical evidence. In advanced courses, I can also draw on my experience with large-scale datasets, causal inference, structural modeling, and machine learning to develop students’ empirical skills. Using Stata, Python, R, and Excel, I aim to teach students not only how to implement analytical methods, but also how to select appropriate methods, assess their assumptions, interpret results critically, and communicate evidence to academic and policy audiences.

Overall, I want students to leave my classroom with the curiosity to ask meaningful economic questions, the analytical tools to investigate them, and the judgment to use evidence responsibly. Whether they pursue careers in economics, public policy, business, or other fields, I hope they will recognize incentives and constraints, evaluate policy tradeoffs, and communicate their reasoning clearly. At the Ford School, I would be prepared to teach core economics and public policy courses and to develop electives in development and climate policy. In this interdisciplinary professional environment, I would help students use economics not only to understand public problems, but also to make informed and effective policy decisions.